Improving the Reels Experience on Instagram

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PRODUCT OVERVIEW

Description

Launched by Instagram in 2020, Reels is a short-form video feature designed to compete with platforms like TikTok. It allows users to create and discover short, entertaining videos up to 90 seconds long.

Reels is integrated directly into the Instagram app, leveraging its massive existing user base. It offers a suite of creative tools including audio, AR effects, and editing features.

The feature focuses on content creation, discovery through a dedicated feed, and monetization for creators, making it a critical component of Instagram's engagement and growth strategy.

Competitors

TikTok

YouTube Shorts

Snapchat Spotlight

Triller

Stats

2B+
Monthly Active Users

200B+
Daily Plays

45%
Market Share in US

50%
Total Time on Insta

91%
Gen Z Watch Weekly

140+
Countries

PRODUCT OVERVIEW

Business Model

Advertisement & Creator Economy

Monetization primarily through targeted video ads in the Reels feed and empowering creators with tools for brand partnerships and direct monetization.



Users of Reels

- Content Creators
- Viewers & Followers
- Brands & Businesses
- Influencers & Marketers
- Artists & Musicians
- Educators & Niche Experts

Key Features

- Advanced Editing Tools
- Extensive Audio Library
- AR Effects and Filters
- Remix and Duet Features
- Templates for Easy Creation
- Seamless Sharing to Feed/Stories
- Interactive Stickers (Polls, Q&A)

Additional Revenue

- Creator Subscriptions
- Shopping Tags & E-commerce
- Gifting and Tipping Features
- Branded Content & Partnerships
- Affiliate Marketing Links
- Creator Marketplace

USER PERSONA



Maya Singh

22 year old Female
University Student in Mumbai

Concerns

Content Discovery Fatigue:
Maya struggles with the repetitive nature of the algorithm, often seeing the same trends and sounds. She wants more variety and content that truly aligns with her niche interests.

Pressure to Perform:
As a creator, she feels the pressure to constantly produce high-engagement content. The unpredictable nature of the algorithm can be discouraging when videos she's proud of don't perform well.

Negative Social Comparison:
Endless scrolling through highly curated and successful-looking content sometimes leads to feelings of inadequacy and impacts her mental well-being, making her question her own progress and creativity.

Goals

Creative Expression & Community:
Maya's primary goal is to use Reels as a platform to share her passion for sustainable fashion and connect with a like-minded community.

Entertainment and Trend Discovery:
She uses Reels for daily entertainment, to discover new music, and to stay updated on viral trends that she can adapt for her own content.

Skill Development:
She aims to improve her video editing and storytelling skills. She looks for new features, effects, and tutorials to enhance the quality of her Reels.

Meaningful Engagement:
Beyond likes, she seeks genuine conversations and feedback in her comments section to build a loyal and interactive following.

Inspiration & Learning:
She follows other creators to draw inspiration for her studies, hobbies, and personal style, treating Reels as a visual discovery engine.

PROBLEM IDENTIFICATION

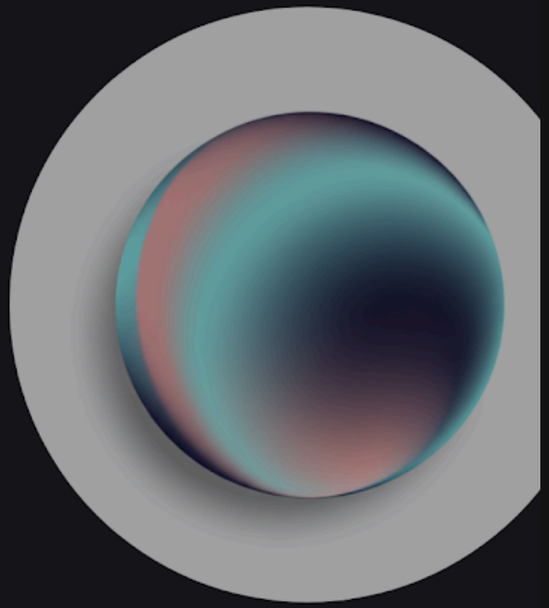
The problem we set out to solve is to **improve Reels content discovery** to increase user engagement by focusing on watch time and creator follows.

This has the following anchors:

Watch time Creator follows Share frequency

Thus to influence any of these metrics we have to make sure our users discover more relevant content or connect with more creators.

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Engagement = Watch Time x Creator Follows x No. of Sessions
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Stakeholders in this problem

Viewers Creators Advertisers Instagram

USER JOURNEY MAP

Reels User Journey

	Discovery	Consumption	Consideration	Creation	Sharing
Stage	User opens Instagram	User starts watching Reels	User gets an idea	User records & edits a Reel	User posts the Reel
Goals	To be entertained	Find interesting content	To create something similar	To create an engaging Reel	To get views and likes
Steps					
Touchpoints	Opens the app	Navigates to Reels tab	Saves audio / effect	Uses creation tools	Writes caption, clicks share
Emotions	🙂	😄	🤩	🤔	🤞
Pain points	Irrelevant content	Repetitive trends	Hard to find trending audio	Complex editing tools	Anxiety about performance

PRODUCT TEARDOWN CASE STUDY 16:9

REELS PRIORITIZATION

Problem / Opportunity	Reach	Impact	Confidence	Effort	Score
Lack of clear categorization for Reels content (e.g., no tags or topic filters)	8	8	75%	5	90
Inefficient discovery of niche content creators; algorithmic suggestions are too broad	9	7	80%	6	84
Limited creative tools compared to competitors (e.g., advanced editing, templates)	7	6	90%	4	75
Difficulty in tracking engagement metrics for individual Reels performance over time	5	8	85%	7	60
Inconsistent video quality and playback issues across different devices	6	5	70%	8	52

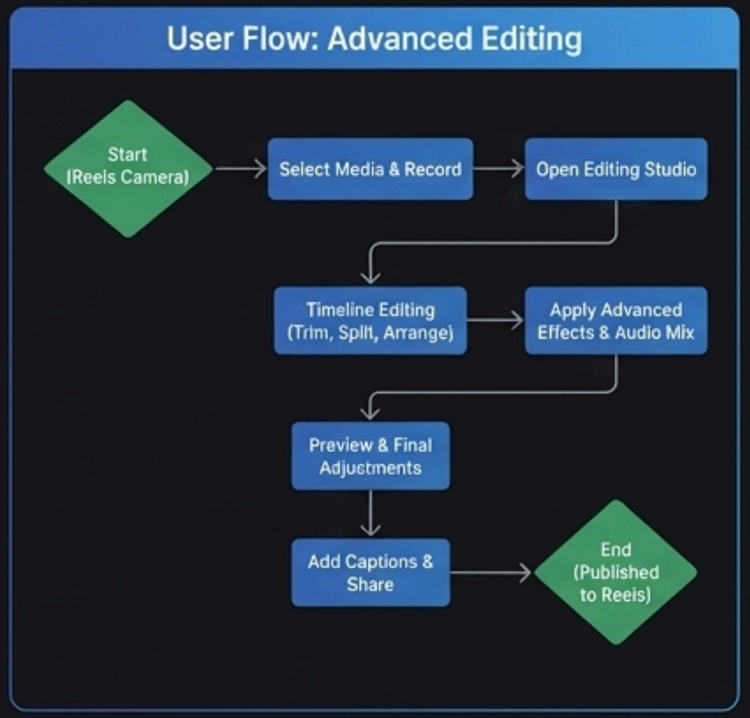
Based on the RICE framework (Reach x Impact x Confidence / Effort), the problems with the highest potential scores of 90 and 84 have been identified for immediate prioritization to significantly improve the Instagram Reels experience and creator satisfaction.

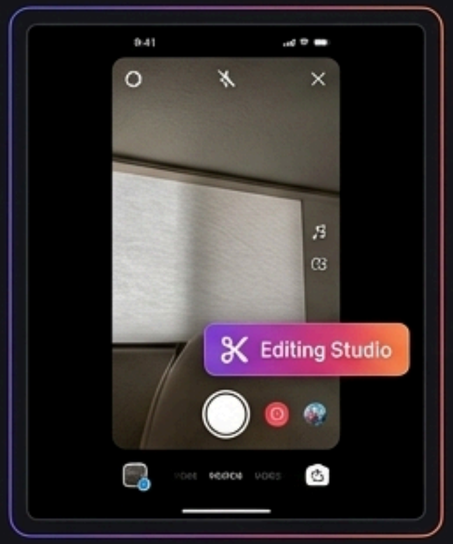
SOLUTION

Introducing Instagram Reels: Enhanced Editing Tools

The goal is to empower creators with pro-level video editing capabilities directly within the Reels camera, reducing friction and increasing content quality.

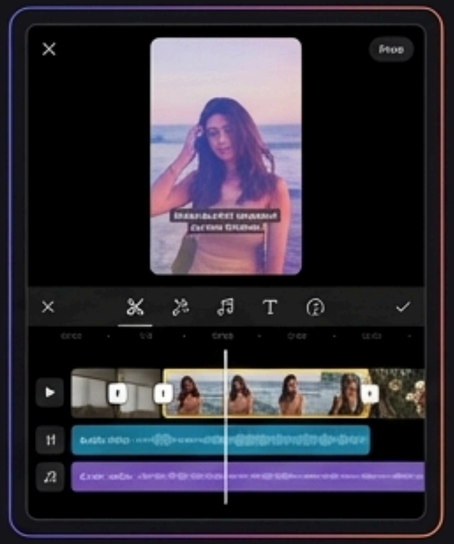
It should enable users to effortlessly trim, splice, add advanced effects, and manage multi-track audio before publishing, streamlining the creation process.





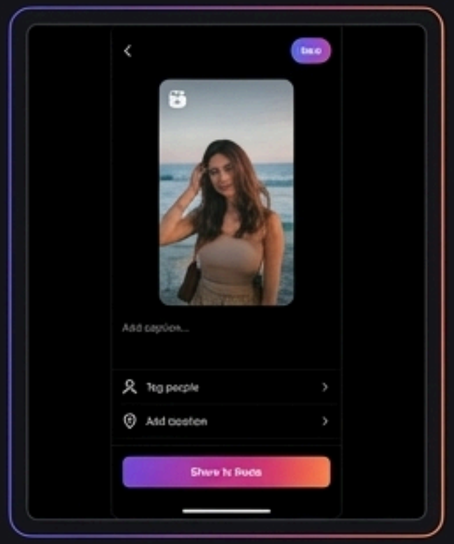
Reels Camera & Entry

Entry point from the Reels camera to access the dedicated Editing Studio.



Editing Studio Interface

Intuitive timeline with precise trimming, multi-track audio, and advanced effect overlays.



Preview & Share

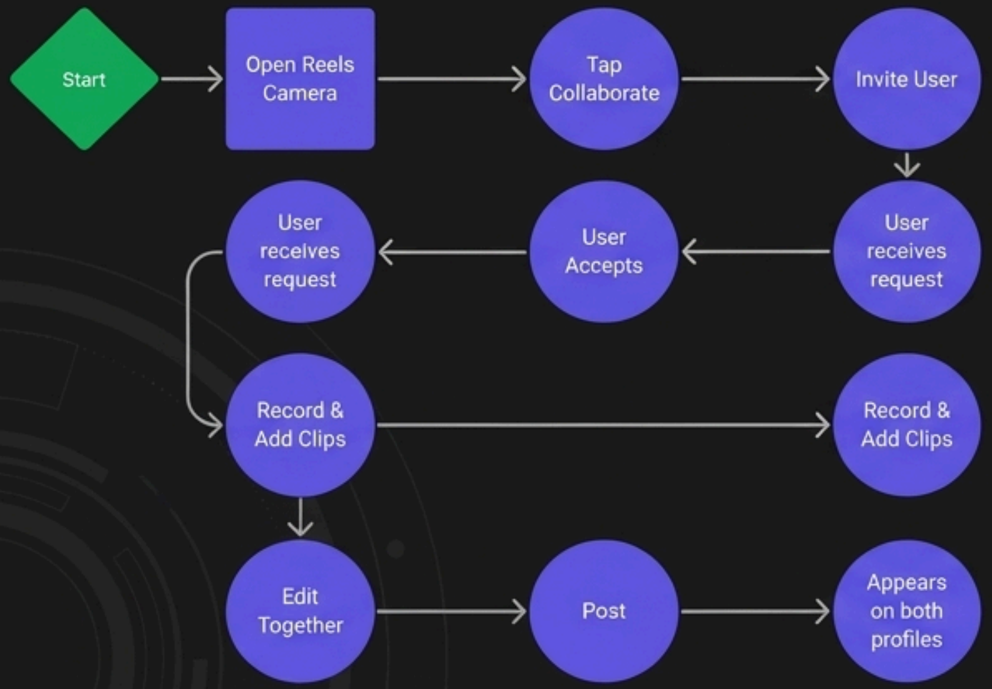
Final preview with options to add captions and share directly to the Reels feed.

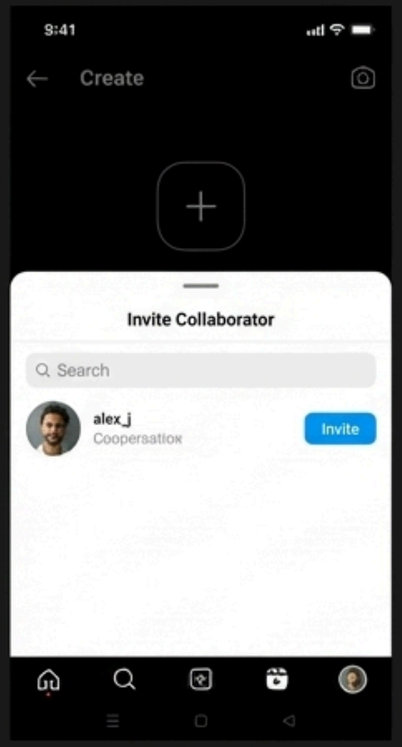
→ Next: Impact Analysis

SOLUTION

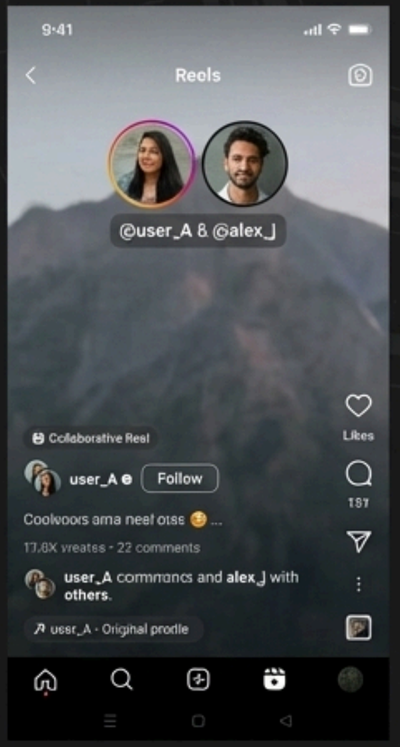
Introducing Collaborative Reels

The goal is to foster community and increase engagement by allowing multiple users to contribute clips to a single, shared Reel. This feature addresses the need for more interactive and co-creative content formats. Users can invite friends to collaborate, combine their clips, and post the final Reel to both their profiles, expanding reach and encouraging participation.





Left: User invites a collaborator during Reel creation.



Right: The final collaborative Reel appears on both profiles, showing shared authorship.

REELS SUCCESS METRICS

User-Centric

Increased Engagement

Likes, comments, & shares per Reel

Clicks on 'Share' CTA

Higher Content Creation

Number of Reels created by users

Reel creation attempts

Longer Viewing Time

Average time spent watching Reels

Session duration in Reels tab

Product-Centric

Growth in DAU

Daily Active Users engaging with Reels

Frequency of app opens

Increase in Ad Revenue

Revenue generated from Reels ads

Number of ad impressions

Tirne-frame = 1 quarter

Implies metric magnitude

CONCLUSION

We aimed to understand and improve the Instagram Reels experience to drive higher engagement and user retention, focusing on content creation and discovery. After a thorough product teardown, we identified critical areas for growth.

Problems Identified:

1. High friction for new creators to produce high-quality short-form video content.
2. Limited discovery of original, niche content outside of viral trends.
3. Lack of clear monetization pathways for emerging Reels creators.

Solutions:

1. Enhanced Reels Creation Suite with AI-powered editing tools and templates.
2. Integrated 'Creators Fund' and better algorithmic matching for niche content discovery.